As a young widow, Sonali Potdar braved taunts from fellow students and the society at large all the time. "They would criticise me for studying despite being a widow.... I was even derided for wearing a salwar-kameez," recalls the resident of Ambap village in Kolhapur district in western Maharashtra. Sonali's husband Sunil passed away 15 years ago. Saddled with two small children, Sonali, now 42, soldiered on, completed her graduation and qualified to be a teacher. A journey that has been anything but easy.



Photographs by MANDAR DEODHAR

TO NEW BEGINNINGS Widows of Ambap village in Kolhapur perform puja at a temple

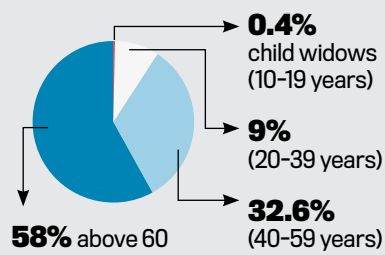
Like many other regions of Maharashtra, Kolhapur, located in Maharashtra's sugar belt with an economy fuelled by a mix of agriculture, industry, educational institutions and co-operatives, too tends to cling to hoary traditions and stifling patriarchal norms handed down the ages. Ostracising widows is one of them. A husband's demise doesn't just entail the symbolic removal of the mangalsutra and toe rings (ornaments that adorn married women) or the wiping off of kumkum (sindoor/vermilion), and smashing bangles. Widows are also 'inauspicious' and barred from attending religious and social gatherings like weddings and birth celebrations and even the aarti during the Ganesh festival. The 'seclusion' extends to denial of job opportunities and property rights and, in some cases, even abuse and exploitation.

However, change is finally in the air. Villages in Maharashtra are trying to tackle this social evil and ensure that widows live life with dignity. The mass-driven movement began in Herwad in Kolhapur district in May 2022, and has spread to other villages, who have approved resolutions banning the rituals associated with widowhood. Women will no longer be forced to remove their mangalsutras or other such markers announcing their widowhood status. The decision will also ensure they are invited to events like the haldi-kumkum ceremonies celebrated by married women in Maharashtra, and they are not barred from social events or visiting temples. In a bid to boost their social standing, widows will also now hoist the flag in the villages on occasions like Independence Day.

56 MN

NO. OF WIDOWED INDIVIDUALS IN INDIA; 78% ARE WOMEN

As expected, a majority of widows are seniors



Source: 2011 Census

HERWAD SHOWS THE WAY

The seeds of this social revolution were sowed in June 2020 when former art teacher-turned-social activist Pramod Zinjade was at the funeral of an associate in Solapur district. The pyre was burning when he noticed a commotion. Zinjade realised that the man's widow was surrounded by a group of women who were forcibly wiping off her kumkum, breaking her glass bangles and mangalsutra, and removing her *jodvi* (toe rings). "The lady was pleading with them to let her keep the ornaments as a memory of her husband but the women did not relent. I decided then that no woman should be forced to undergo this ordeal," recalls the 67-year-old Zinjade.

Then, in March 2022, the Karmala-based Zinjade, a diabetic, had a health scare in the middle of the night. The next morning, he went to the local tehsildar's office and notarised an affidavit stating that after his death, wife Alka should be allowed to apply kumkum and retain her mangalsutra and bangles. The document also made it clear that she had the right to file a complaint against anyone who tried to force her to do otherwise. The officials were surprised to see the unusual request, with the steno who typed it out even advising Zinjade to seek psychiatric help.

The story soon made it to the media and more people came forward to say